IR Exam Case Bank

> **How to use.** For any question, pick ONE theory as your main answer and ONE as your rebutted counter. Each row = that theory's angle, the **named concepts** to use (all from the course/notes), two empirical examples, and the weakness to expect in the counterargument. ⚠️ = forced fit (that theory struggles here; good to know for picking a *counter*, risky as a *main*).
>
> **5 theories:** Realism (structural) · Liberal institutionalism · Liberal internationalism · Constructivism · Critical theory. Examples are *named only* — flesh out the identity/mechanism story yourself in the essay.
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> **The named concepts per theory (use only these):**
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> - **Realism:** anarchy · self-help · security dilemma · balance of power · relative vs absolute gains · polarity · power transition · deterrence · bandwagoning.
> - **Lib. institutionalism:** absolute gains · institutions · international regime (Krasner) · the 4 mechanisms (*shadow of the future · information/monitoring · reciprocity/enforcement · interdependence*) · complex interdependence (sensitivity/vulnerability) · collective security.
> - **Lib. internationalism:** Kantian triangle (democracy + interdependence + IOs) · democratic peace · domestic preferences / opening the black box.
> - **Constructivism:** identity · norms · logic of appropriateness (vs logic of consequences) · social construction · intersubjective meaning (social vs material facts) · "anarchy is what states make of it" · socialisation.
> - **Critical theory:** hegemony (Gramsci) · class / Marxism · world-systems (core–periphery, Wallerstein) · ideology / legitimation · postcolonialism.

★ The core 20 — memorise THESE, reuse everywhere

Learn these 20 instead of 75. For each: the **facts you'd cite**, then the **same facts deployed across different questions and theories** — that's the whole point, *one event doing work everywhere*. Each bullet = "question → theory → the one-line argument."

1. US–USSR Cold War (1947–91) After WWII the US and USSR emerged as rival superpowers split by ideology (capitalism vs communism). For ~45 years they never fought *directly* but competed through a nuclear arms race, proxy wars (Korea, Vietnam, Afghanistan) and espionage, under the threat of mutually assured destruction (MAD). Tensions eased in 1970s "détente," yielding arms-control treaties (SALT, then the 1987 INF treaty). It ended with the USSR's collapse in 1991.

- **Q6 arms races** → Realism: the *security dilemma* made each build-up spiral.
- **Q10 rivalry→war/peace** → Realism: *deterrence* (MAD) kept it "cold."
- **Q11 nuclear pursuit** → Realism: both armed for *survival under anarchy*.
- **Q12 decline of great-power war** → Realism: *bipolarity* + MAD = the "long peace."
- **Q8 institutions persist** → Lib. inst.: SALT/INF *regimes* outlived the tension.
- **counter** → Constructivism: the enmity was *constructed* — détente shows identity can shift.

2. Cuban Missile Crisis (1962) The USSR secretly deployed nuclear missiles in Cuba, within striking range of the US mainland. For 13 days the superpowers stood on the brink of nuclear war as the US imposed a naval blockade and demanded their removal. It was resolved when the USSR withdrew the missiles in exchange for a US pledge not to invade Cuba — plus a *secret* US removal of its own missiles from Turkey. The closest the Cold War came to nuclear war.

- **Q10 rivalry→war/peace** → Realism: *brinkmanship* under nuclear shadow, yet rivalry stayed short of war.
- **Q12 decline of GP war** → Realism: *deterrence* forced the climb-down.
- **Q13 acting "against interest"** → Two-level games: the *secret* Turkey swap let each leader satisfy hardliners at home (Level II).

3. NATO (1949–) The North Atlantic Treaty Organization is a collective-defence alliance (an attack on one = an attack on all) formed by Western states to deter the Soviet Union. Its original purpose vanished when the USSR collapsed in 1991 — yet it did not dissolve; it *expanded* eastward, adding former Soviet-bloc states. It remains central today (e.g. the Western response to Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine).

- **Q7 alliances** → Realism: *balancing* a shared threat.
- **Q8 institutions persist** → Lib. inst.: an institution outliving its original purpose (and realism's *embarrassment* — use as counter).
- **Q7 alliances** → Constructivism: a transatlantic *security community* bound by identity, not just threat.
- **Q4 democratic peace** → Lib. intl.: an alliance *of democracies*.

4. The EU (1951–) It began with the European Coal and Steel Community (1951), which pooled the war-making industries (coal, steel) of France and Germany so neither could rearm in secret. From there, European states built ever-deeper economic and political integration — the single market, the euro, shared institutions. The explicit aim was to make war between historic enemies impossible by binding them together. Today 27 members; war among them is now "unthinkable."

- **Q10 rivalry→peace** → Lib. inst.: *complex interdependence* made war too costly.
- **Q12 decline of GP war** → Lib. inst.: institutions + trade ended intra-European war.
- **Q4 democracies don't fight** → Lib. intl.: a club of democracies.
- **Q7 alliances** → Constructivism: a built European *identity* / security community.

5. NPT (1968) The Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty is a near-universal regime: non-nuclear states pledge never to acquire nuclear weapons (and accept inspections), in exchange for access to civilian nuclear tech and a loose promise by the five recognised nuclear powers (US, Russia, UK, France, China) to work toward disarmament. It created a two-tier system of nuclear "haves" and "have-nots." Most states have stayed non-nuclear under it.

- **Q11 nuclear pursuit** → Lib. inst.: a *regime* raising proliferation's cost → most states don't build.
- **Q2 abandon capability** → Lib. inst.: the regime made disarmament safe.
- **Q5 compliance** → Lib. inst.: reciprocity + monitoring → states obey an unenforceable rule.
- **Q3 / Q11 counter** → Critical: a *two-tier order* — the powerful keep bombs, the rest give them up.

6. Kazakhstan / Ukraine denuclearisation (Budapest, 1994) When the USSR collapsed, Kazakhstan and Ukraine suddenly held part of the world's largest nuclear arsenal on their soil. Both gave up *all* the weapons and joined the NPT as non-nuclear states, in exchange for the 1994 Budapest Memorandum —

security assurances from the US, UK and Russia respecting their borders and sovereignty. Russia's 2014 and 2022 attacks on Ukraine later exposed those assurances as hollow.

- **Q2 abandon capability** → Lib. inst.: NPT + assurances made giving up safe.
- **Q2 abandon capability** → Realism: took a great-power *guarantee* instead of keeping costly arms.
- **Q14 sanctions/coercion** → Realism: 2022 showed the guarantee was *hollow* — assurances aren't deterrence.

7. Brazil–Argentina (ABACC, 1991) Regional rivals under military dictatorships, both secretly pursued nuclear weapons in the 1970s–80s. After both *democratised*, they chose mutual trust over the bomb: in 1991 they created ABACC, a joint agency where each inspects the other's nuclear facilities to verify neither is building weapons. Both abandoned their programmes; neither built a bomb — and crucially, they were *equals*, with no great power forcing them.

- **Q2 abandon capability** → Lib. inst.: *reciprocity* + *verification* let rivals disarm without exposure.
- **Q2 abandon capability** → Lib. intl.: *democratisation* flipped the domestic preference.
- **Q15 power transition** → rivals managed it *peacefully*.
- **counter** → kills Critical's "strong coerce weak" line — these were *equals*, uncoerced.

8. US–China today As China rose to rival the US economically, the two became deeply interdependent through trade — while simultaneously competing over Taiwan, advanced technology (semiconductors), and control of the South China Sea. A textbook "power transition": a rising power unsettling the incumbent. Cooperation (trade, climate talks) and rivalry (tariffs, military build-up) run side by side.

- **Q15 power transition** → Realism: *power transition* risks conflict.
- **Q1 cooperate-yet-hostile** → Realism: *relative gains* — cooperate where the balance isn't touched.
- **Q5 compliance** → Realism: follows trade law only while it serves them.
- **Q1 cooperate-yet-hostile** → Constructivism: "rival vs partner" is a *framing*.
- **Q6 arms races** → Realism: tech/military *security dilemma*.

9. Russia–Ukraine / Crimea (2014, 2022) Russia — a permanent UN Security Council member that helped enshrine the sovereignty/territorial-integrity norm — annexed Ukraine's Crimea in 2014 and launched a full-scale invasion in 2022. The West responded with sweeping economic sanctions, which failed to force a withdrawal (helped by Russia's resources and Chinese trade). One of the starkest great-power violations of the sovereignty rule since 1945.

- **Q3 great powers break rules** → Realism: it *could*; Constructivism: "*Russian world*" identity; Critical: rewriting rules it authored. *(one case, three framings)*
- **Q1 cooperate-yet-hostile** → Realism: Russia–EU *gas* trade alongside security hostility.
- **Q14 sanctions fail** → Realism: *survival* + Chinese help blunted them.
- **Q10 rivalry→war** → Constructivism: enmity hardened into invasion.

10. US–Iraq 2003 The US — with the UK and a "coalition of the willing" — invaded Iraq to topple Saddam Hussein *without* UN Security Council authorisation, bypassing the Charter's rules on the use of force that the US itself helped write in 1945. It was justified on later-discredited WMD claims. A leading example of a great power acting above the international law it created.

- **Q3 great powers break rules** → Realism (it had the power), Constructivism (*exceptionalism* — above the rules it authored), Critical (hegemonic/resource interest). *(one case, three framings)*

- **Q5 compliance** → why great powers *don't* comply.
- **Q9 intervention** → Critical: "humanitarian/WMD" *cover* for interest.

11. WWI / 1914 A rising, newly-unified Germany challenged British dominance amid a naval arms race and two rigid alliance blocs. The assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand triggered a chain of alliance commitments that dragged all the great powers into catastrophic war — *despite* record levels of trade and interdependence among them, which utterly failed to prevent it (the famous rebuttal to "trade brings peace").

- **Q10 rivalry→war** & **Q15 power transition** → Realism: *power transition + security dilemma*.
- **Q6 arms races** → Realism: the Anglo-German naval race.
- **Q12 / Q10 counter to liberalism** → interdependence *did not* prevent war — the knockout rebuttal to liberal "trade = peace."
- **counter** → Critical: imperial/capitalist rivalry.

12. WTO / global trade regime The World Trade Organization (1995, building on GATT) created binding rules and a dispute-settlement system for global trade — largely obeyed for decades even by powerful states that lost cases. Yet the US, its chief architect, later undercut it: imposing unilateral tariffs and blocking appointments to the appellate body, paralysing enforcement. Shows both institutional compliance *and* great-power defection.

- **Q5 compliance** → Lib. inst.: *reputation + reciprocity* → mostly obeyed.
- **Q8 institutions persist** → Lib. inst.: survives without coercion.
- **Q15 power transition** → Lib. inst.: *socialised* a rising China (WTO entry).
- **Q3 great powers break rules** → Realism: the US defies rules it built when convenient.

13. UN Security Council veto At the UN's founding (1945), the five victors of WWII (US, Russia, UK, France, China) made themselves *permanent* members with a veto over any resolution. This entrenched great-power privilege at the heart of the international system — they can block any action against themselves or their allies. A structural inequality written into the "rules of the game."

- **Q3 great powers break rules** → Critical: an institution built to serve the powerful (*"who wrote the rules?"*).
- **Q5 compliance / Q8 persistence** → Realism: institutions *mirror the distribution of power*.
- **Q9 intervention** → interventions get authorised *selectively*, by power.

14. Democratic peace (W. Europe post-1945) Since 1945, Western European democracies — including historic enemies like France and Germany — have not fought one another, and more broadly no two mature democracies have fought a full-scale war. Former battlefields became close partners through the EU and NATO. It's often called the most robust empirical regularity in IR (though "democracy" is contested and edge cases exist).

- **Q4 democracies don't fight** → Lib. intl.: *Kantian triangle* (accountability, interdependence, IOs).
- **Q10 rivalry→peace** & **Q12 decline of war** → Lib. intl.: regime type explains the peace.
- **counter** → Realism: it was shared interests + the US alliance, *not* democracy.

15. Rwanda 1994 vs Somalia 1992 / Libya 2011 In 1994 the world stood by during the Rwandan genocide (~800,000 killed in ~100 days), declining to intervene. Yet it *did* intervene in Somalia (1992,

humanitarian famine relief) and Libya (2011, a NATO air campaign). The glaring inconsistency reveals how *selective* "humanitarian" intervention is — strategically valueless Rwanda got nothing.

- **Q9 intervention** → Constructivism: *selective norms* of who "deserves" protection.
- **Q9 intervention** → Realism: intervention tracks *strategic interest* (Rwanda had none).
- **Q13 acting on norms** → Constructivism: Somalia '92 had little strategic value — *norms*, not interest.

16. Iran nuclear deal / JCPOA (2015) Iran agreed to cap and open its nuclear programme to international inspection in exchange for relief from crippling sanctions — a multilateral deal with the US, EU, Russia and China. In 2018 the US unilaterally *withdrew* under Trump and reimposed sanctions, despite Iran's compliance. Shows both institutional bargaining and how domestic politics can unravel a deal.

- **Q5 compliance** → Lib. inst.: a *regime* trading verification for relief.
- **Q14 sanctions** → sanctions as *leverage* that bought a deal.
- **Q13 / two-level games** → the US withdrawal shows Level-II *domestic politics* undoing a Level-I deal.

17. North Korea Seeking to guarantee regime survival, North Korea pursued nuclear weapons, *withdrew* from the NPT in 2003, and has since conducted repeated nuclear tests. Despite decades of heavy international sanctions, it has kept and expanded its arsenal. The clearest case of a state defying the non-proliferation regime and shrugging off sanctions — because survival outweighs economic pain.

- **Q11 nuclear pursuit** → Realism: *self-help* + *deterrence* for survival.
- **Q5 compliance** → Realism: exited the law when it clashed with survival.
- **Q14 sanctions fail** → Realism: survival trumps economic pain.
- **Q2 counter** → the NPT *defection* that shows institutions can't bind a determined state.

18. South Africa The apartheid regime secretly built six nuclear weapons in the 1980s — then became the *only* state ever to voluntarily dismantle its own arsenal, doing so around 1989–91 as apartheid ended and it joined the NPT. The disarmament coincided with the transition to a new, post-apartheid state identity — the old regime didn't want the bombs in a majority-ruled South Africa's hands.

- **Q2 abandon capability** → Lib. intl.: a new *domestic regime* changed the preference.
- **Q2 abandon capability** → Constructivism: a new post-apartheid *identity* made the bomb inappropriate.
- **Q11 nuclear pursuit** → the rare "built then gave up" case.

19. China & the South China Sea (2016 ruling) China claims most of the South China Sea and built artificial island military bases to enforce it. In 2016 an international tribunal — under the Law of the Sea convention China had itself ratified — ruled its sweeping claims unlawful. China simply *ignored* the ruling and carried on. A rising power openly defying an international law it had signed.

- **Q3 great powers break rules** → Realism: defies law once strong enough; Critical: rules bind the weak, not the powerful.
- **Q5 compliance** → why a great power *ignores* an unenforceable ruling.
- **Q15 power transition** → a rising power testing the order.

20. Trump "America First" (2017–) The Trump administration pulled the US out of multiple agreements it had shaped — the Paris climate accord, the Iran deal (JCPOA), the WHO — and imposed tariffs on allies and rivals alike. These moves were driven by *domestic* political appeal (the "America First"

base) rather than any systemic/strategic pressure. An example of domestic politics, not the international system, steering foreign policy.

- **Q3 great powers break rules** → Lib. intl. / FPA: *domestic coalitions*, not the system, drove it.
- **Q13 acting against systemic interest** → Two-level games / FPA: Level-II politics overrode the "national interest."
- **Q5 compliance** → why a state *exits* institutions it built.

Under pressure: pick the question → scan for 2 cases with a bullet for it → state each one's facts, then run your theory's framing. Note how often the *same* case (9, 10, 11, 14) appears under many questions — that's why 20 is enough.

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1. Why do rival states cooperate in one area while staying hostile in another?

Theory	Explanation (1-line)	Concepts (named)	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Cooperate where it doesn't shift the relative balance; hostile where it does	relative vs absolute gains, balance of power, self-help	Russia–EU gas (vs NATO); India–China trade (vs border)	Struggles to explain *durable, institutionalised* cooperation
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions make cooperation safe in one domain	institutions, international regime, reciprocity	US–USSR arms control; US–China climate talks amid trade war	Can't explain persisting hostility
Lib. internationalism ⚠️	Domestic preferences favour cooperation on some issues, not others	domestic preferences, the black box	US–China (business lobby vs security hawks)	Thin on *why rivalry persists*; forced
Constructivism	Different shared meanings/identities built per issue-area	identity, intersubjective meaning, "anarchy is what states make of it"	US–China (partner vs rival framing)	Weak at predicting *which* area turns cooperative
Critical theory	Cooperation serves dominant economic interests; hostility masks it	hegemony, class, world-systems	Russia–EU energy capital; Gulf states–West	Hard to test; over-reads everything as capital

2. Why do some states abandon a military capability they've already developed?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Abandon when a guarantee/alliance covers the need, or coerced	deterrence, balance of power, self-help	Kazakhstan/Ukraine (assurances); Germany/Japan post-45	Distrusts institutions — awkward with voluntary treaty disarmament
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions make verified mutual disarmament safe	reciprocity/enforcement, information/monitoring, international regime	Brazil–Argentina (ABACC); Kazakhstan (NPT)	Can't explain defection (North Korea leaving NPT)
Lib. internationalism	A new domestic coalition (democratisation) drops the programme	domestic preferences, the black box, democratic peace	Brazil & Argentina (post-dictatorship); South Africa	Needs a domestic shift — silent when there isn't one
Constructivism	A norm (non-proliferation) reshapes identity	norms, socialisation, logic of appropriateness	nuclear taboo; South Africa's post-apartheid identity	Weak where disarmament is clearly coerced
Critical theory	The strong pressure the weak to disarm while keeping their own	hegemony, world-systems (core–periphery)	NPT haves/have-nots; Libya/Iraq WMD disarmament	Can't explain equal-power mutual disarmament (Brazil–Argentina)

3. Why are great powers more likely than small states to break rules they helped create?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Relative power lets them ignore rules; small states can't	relative gains, self-help, polarity	US–Iraq 2003; Russia–Crimea/Ukraine	Can't explain why great powers *ever* obey
Lib. institutionalism	Great powers depend on institutions less, so the costs bite less	complex interdependence (vulnerability), reciprocity	US tariffs/WTO; US & ICC	Under-predicts how often great powers *do* comply
Lib. internationalism ⚠️	Domestic politics (nationalism, executives) push rule-breaking	domestic preferences, the black box	Trump "America First"; Brexit	Doesn't track the *great/small* split cleanly; forced
Constructivism	Great powers' identity = exceptional/above the rules they authored	identity, logic of appropriateness	US exceptionalism (Iraq, ICC); Russia's great-power self-image	Must show identity, not just the act (reads as realism)
Critical theory	The order is built to serve the powerful; "rules" bind only the weak	hegemony, ideology/legitimation	UNSC veto; US & ICC exemption	Hard to falsify

4. Why do democracies rarely fight each other?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism ⚠️	Not democracy — shared interests, alliances, Cold War structure	balance of power, polarity	NATO democracies vs USSR; US–UK alliance	Denies a robust empirical finding; defensive
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions + interdependence make war too costly	complex interdependence, institutions, absolute gains	EU members; Bretton Woods order	Doesn't explain the *democracy-specific* pattern
Lib. internationalism	Accountability, public opinion restrain war between republics	Kantian triangle, democratic peace	no two mature democracies fought (20th c.); EU	"Democracy" is contested; edge-case wars exist
Constructivism	Democracies share an in-group identity — war feels inappropriate	identity, norms, logic of appropriateness	transatlantic community; EU "security community"	Hard to measure "identity"; risks circularity
Critical theory ⚠️	"Democratic peace" masks shared capitalist-class interest	class, hegemony, ideology	Western bloc cohesion; global capital order	Strains against the clean empirical record

5. Why do states comply with international law no one can enforce?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Only when it serves interests / the powerful want it	self-help, balance of power	UNCLOS when convenient; great-power selectivity	Can't explain costly compliance
Lib. institutionalism	Reputation + reciprocity + shadow of the future make it pay	reciprocity/enforcement, shadow of the future, international regime	WTO rulings mostly obeyed; trade law	Weak vs great-power defection
Lib. internationalism	Domestic courts/groups internalise and demand compliance	domestic preferences, the black box	ECHR in domestic courts; EU law	Varies hugely by regime type
Constructivism	Law is internalised as "appropriate"	norms, logic of appropriateness, socialisation	decolonisation norm; torture taboo	Can't explain brazen violations
Critical theory	Law legitimises the powerful; compliance = consent to hegemony	hegemony, ideology/legitimation	investment/trade law favouring the core	Over-reads; hard to test

6. Why do arms races happen?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Defensive build-ups look offensive under anarchy	security dilemma, self-help, relative gains	US–USSR Cold War; pre-1914 naval race	Can't explain restraint/de-escalation
Lib. institutionalism	Failure of institutions to provide information/reassurance	information/monitoring, international regime	arms-control treaties that *stopped* races (INF)	Explains the *fix* better than the *race*
Lib. internationalism	Domestic lobbies (military-industrial) drive it	domestic preferences, the black box	US defence lobby; Cold War procurement	Needs a specific domestic driver
Constructivism ⚠️	Rival identities make the other's arms seem threatening	identity, intersubjective meaning (social vs material)	India–Pakistan rivalry; US–USSR enmity	Thin on *why build-ups spiral*
Critical theory	Arms racing serves capital/the militarist order	class, hegemony	arms-industry profits; Cold War economy	Hard to falsify

7. Why do states form alliances?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Balance against a greater threat (or bandwagon with it)	balance of power, bandwagoning, polarity	NATO vs USSR; anti-Napoleon coalitions	Struggles with alliance *persistence* after threat ends (NATO post-91)
Lib. institutionalism	Alliances as institutions lowering cooperation costs	institutions, reciprocity, collective security	NATO's enduring structure; EU defence	Under-weights raw threat
Lib. internationalism	Shared regime type / domestic affinity	democratic peace, domestic preferences	NATO democracies; US–UK	Doesn't explain alliances *with* autocracies
Constructivism	Shared identity/community, not just threat	identity, "security community"	transatlantic community; ASEAN	Weak when alliances are purely instrumental
Critical theory	Alliances entrench the hegemon's order	hegemony, world-systems	US alliance system; client states	Over-reads; hard to test

8. Why do international institutions persist even when they can't compel states?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	They persist only while they serve the powerful	self-help, balance of power	UNSC veto; IMF weighted votes	Can't explain institutions outliving the founder's interest
Lib. institutionalism	They lower transaction costs, solve collective-action problems	institutions, international regime, shadow of the future	WTO; WHO; UN system	Over-optimistic vs great-power sidelining
Lib. internationalism	Domestic groups benefit and lobby to keep them	domestic preferences, the black box	EU constituencies; trade lobbies	Varies by state
Constructivism	They become taken-for-granted, part of "normal" order	norms, socialisation, intersubjective meaning	the UN's legitimacy; sovereignty norm	Can't explain sudden collapses
Critical theory	They reproduce the hegemonic order and look "natural"	hegemony (Gramsci), ideology/legitimation	IMF/World Bank conditionality; Bretton Woods	Hard to falsify

9. Why do states (sometimes) intervene in humanitarian crises?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Only when strategic interests coincide	self-help, balance of power	Libya 2011 (interest-aligned); Rwanda 1994 (non-intervention)	Can't explain genuinely costly intervention
Lib. institutionalism	Collective action via IOs/authorisation	collective security, institutions	UN-authorised missions; R2P	Weak when IOs are paralysed
Lib. internationalism	Public opinion/domestic pressure drives it	democratic peace, domestic preferences	"CNN effect"; democratic publics	Inconsistent across cases
Constructivism	Widening norms of who "deserves" protection	norms, logic of appropriateness, socialisation	Somalia 1992; R2P norm emergence	Can't explain non-intervention (Rwanda)
Critical theory	"Humanitarian" cover for hegemonic/economic interests	hegemony, postcolonialism, ideology	Iraq/Libya resource angle	Cynical; hard to test

10. Why do some rivalries end in war while others stay peaceful?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Power shifts / security dilemma tip rivalry into war	power transition, security dilemma	WWI (rising Germany); US–USSR *avoided* war (deterrence)	Indeterminate — predicts both
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions + interdependence raise war's cost	complex interdependence, institutions	EU ending Franco-German war; 1914 (failed)	Interdependence didn't stop 1914
Lib. internationalism	Regime type — democracies avoid war with each other	democratic peace, Kantian triangle	Western Europe post-45	Edge cases
Constructivism	Whether the rival is constructed as enemy or competitor	identity, "anarchy is what states make of it"	US–Canada (amity) vs US–USSR (enmity)	Hard to predict ex ante
Critical theory ⚠️	War/peace reflects material/class structures	class, world-systems	WWI imperial rivalry	Coarse; hard to test

11. Why do states pursue nuclear weapons?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Security under anarchy; deterrence vs a threat	self-help, deterrence, security dilemma	North Korea; Pakistan (vs India)	Can't explain restraint by capable states (Japan)
Lib. institutionalism	Regimes (NPT) raise costs → most *don't*	international regime, reciprocity	NPT near-universal membership	Explains non-pursuit better than pursuit
Lib. internationalism	Domestic politics/prestige coalitions	domestic preferences, the black box	India's domestic drivers	Needs a case-specific coalition
Constructivism	Prestige/identity ("a great power has the bomb"), or a taboo restrains	identity, norms	France's force de frappe; nuclear taboo	Competing identity claims cut both ways
Critical theory ⚠️	The order lets the core keep bombs, denies the periphery	hegemony, world-systems (core–periphery)	NPT haves vs have-nots	Doesn't explain *why* a given state builds

12. Why has great-power war declined since 1945?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Nuclear deterrence + bipolar stability	deterrence, polarity, balance of power	US–USSR Cold War peace (MAD)	Can't explain peace among non-nuclear democracies
Lib. institutionalism	Dense institutions + interdependence raise costs	complex interdependence, institutions	EU; Bretton Woods/WTO order	Didn't stop proxy wars
Lib. internationalism	Spread of democracy → democratic peace	democratic peace, Kantian triangle	post-45 Western Europe	Doesn't cover autocracies' restraint
Constructivism	A norm against great-power war took hold	norms, socialisation	WWI/WWII "never again"; war delegitimised	Hard to isolate the norm's effect
Critical theory	US hegemony imposed a stable (profitable) order	hegemony, world-systems	Bretton Woods; dollar order	Over-credits structure

13. Why do states sometimes act against their material interests?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism ⚠️	They don't, really — apparent losses serve power/security	relative gains, self-help	costly signalling; alliance commitments	Explains the behaviour away rather than *for* it
Lib. institutionalism	Short-term cost for long-term reciprocal gain	shadow of the future, reciprocity, absolute gains	sunk reputational costs; treaty compliance	Stretches "interest" to fit
Lib. internationalism	A domestic coalition's interest ≠ the "national" one	domestic preferences, the black box	tariffs hurting consumers; farm subsidies	Needs the coalition identified
Constructivism	Identity/norms override material calculation	identity, logic of appropriateness, norms	Germany's post-45 restraint; costly norm compliance	Hard to prove norms *caused* it
Critical theory	"National interest" masks a *class* interest being served	class, ideology/legitimation	austerity serving capital	Hard to falsify

14. Why do economic sanctions often fail?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Targets prioritise survival; rivals help them	self-help, balance of power	Russia post-2014/2022; North Korea	Under-weights when sanctions *do* work
Lib. institutionalism	Work only with multilateral coordination/monitoring	collective security, information/monitoring	UN vs unilateral sanctions; leaky regimes	Hard to sustain coordination
Lib. internationalism	The target's regime insulates elites from pain	domestic preferences, the black box	authoritarian resilience (Iran, NK)	Varies by regime
Constructivism	Sanctions can harden a besieged national identity	identity, norms	Iran; Russia's "fortress" narrative	Hard to measure
Critical theory	Sanctions reinforce core dominance; hurt the periphery's poor	world-systems (core–periphery), hegemony	sanctions' humanitarian toll	Doesn't explain *failure* vs success

15. Why do power transitions (rising powers) cause conflict?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	A riser unsettles the balance → security dilemma, war risk	power transition, balance of power, security dilemma	US–China today; rising Germany pre-1914	Many transitions *don't* end in war
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions can socialise a riser peacefully	institutions, complex interdependence	China into WTO; post-45 order	Riser may defect once strong
Lib. internationalism	Depends on the riser's regime type	democratic peace, domestic preferences	democratic vs autocratic risers	Hard to generalise
Constructivism	Conflict if the riser is constructed as a threatening "other"	identity, intersubjective meaning	US–China threat framing; UK→US peaceful transition	Why peaceful sometimes? identity under-determines
Critical theory	Transition = struggle over who controls the capitalist order	hegemony, world-systems	British→American hegemony; US–China	Coarse; hard to test

Quick picking guide

- **Security / war / weapons** (6, 10, 11, 12, 15) → **realism** strongest main, **constructivism** or **liberalism** as counter.
- **Cooperation / law / institutions** (1, 2, 5, 8) → **liberalism** main, **realism** or **critical** counter.
- **Identity / norms / "why against interest"** (4, 13) → **constructivism** main, **realism** counter.
- **Who-benefits / hierarchy** (3, 9) → **critical theory** makes a sharp counter; realism/constructivism as main.
- ⚠️ rows = the theory to attack in your rebuttal, not to defend as your main.